Audit Clinical Evidence



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TO Editorial Office, *Medicine*, Wolters Kluwer
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CC Megan Larkin, Senior Publisher, and Hannah Zhang, Publisher

RE **Audit report ACE2026001 on two articles published in Medicine**

2019a Abdelbasset, W. K., & Alqahtani, B. A. (2019). A randomized controlled trial on the impact of moderate-intensity continuous aerobic exercise on the depression status of middle-aged patients with congestive heart failure. *Medicine*, 98(17), e15344. DOI 10.1097/MD.0000000000015344

2019b Abdelbasset, W. K., Alqahtani, B. A., Alrawaili, S. M., Ahmed, A. S., Elnegamy, T. E., Ibrahim, A. A., & Soliman, G. S. (2019). Similar effects of low to moderate-intensity exercise program vs moderate-intensity continuous exercise program on depressive disorder in heart failure patients. *Medicine*, 98(32), e16820. DOI 10.1097/MD.0000000000016820

Dear Editors,

Audit Clinical Evidence (ACE) is an independent initiative that publishes reproducible audits of clinical research. We write to make you aware of our audit of the two articles cited above. The report, ACE2026001, is published on the ACE website and permanently archived with a DOI. A copy is enclosed.

Report **https://auditclinicalevidence.org/reports/ACE2026001**
Archive **https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22861278**

The audit finds serious errors in both articles. The trial data in these two articles are duplicated across three published studies, the third published in *Clinics*. The means and standard deviations reported for the primary outcome, the PHQ-9, could not have come from a real data set. Several of the reported test statistics are also not possible given the summary statistics reported beside them. Furthermore, the 2019a article names its first author, Walid Kamal Abdelbasset, as the editor who handled its peer review. The reported effect sizes are extreme and contaminate later meta-analyses of exercise for depression. In total, the report documents 29 errors or integrity concerns across the three articles, 25 of which concern the two articles in *Medicine*. Every number in the report is computed from the articles' published values with code that accompanies the report, so each finding can be checked independently. On the basis of these findings, ACE recommends retraction of both articles. The decision belongs to the journal.

Because Dr Abdelbasset is listed on the editorial board of *Medicine*, we have written to the editorial office and the publisher directly. We ask that the journal assess the report under its research integrity procedures and the COPE guidelines, and let us know the outcome. ACE has not contacted the authors. We would welcome a response from the authors and will publish any response alongside the report, in full or quoted in part, as described in our correspondence policy at https://auditclinicalevidence.org/disclaimers.

ACE records its correspondence with journals on a public page, https://auditclinicalevidence.org/correspondence, which shows the date this letter was sent, the date of any reply, and the journal's decision. If this letter should go to a different office, we would be grateful for the correct address.

Sincerely,

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on behalf of Audit Clinical Evidence